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W E D N E S D A Y , D E C E M B E R 1 0 , 2 0 2 5

## Pushing hard for tax relief, Wu still runs into Senate

Lawmakers indicate it's too late to get support

By Niki Griswold  
GLOBE STAFF

Days ahead of a key deadline for the city to set property tax rates, Boston Mayor Michelle Wu is ratcheting up her pressure campaign on state lawmakers to approve a plan she says is crucial to prevent painful increases in residents' bills. But she's still getting a cool reception from the Senate, whose leader suggested in a statement to the Globe on Monday that Wu's renewed efforts are coming too late.

From a video on Bluesky, to her first mayoral "Ask me anything" thread on Reddit, and with the mobilization of her union and City Council allies, Wu is taking direct aim at the legislators who have blocked her proposal in the past, in some cases targeting them by name as she leverages her influence in the city to try and sway her counterparts on Beacon Hill.

It's an increasingly sharp-elbowed approach by the recently reelected mayor, who has watched with evident frustration as her legislation has stalled in the Senate three times since June last year.

For nearly two years, Wu has been advocating for the Legislature to approve a proposal that would allow her to temporarily shift more of the city's property tax burden onto commercial real estate to mitigate double-digit tax increases for residential property owners. Last year, the proposal died in the Senate after Wu spent months conducting town halls on the subject, speaking with lawmakers, and negoti-

TAXES, Page A7

## Priest stands behind message on ICE

Says his Nativity protest is necessary in divisive times

By Brian MacQuarrie  
GLOBE STAFF

DEDHAM — The Rev. Stephen Josoma has been the only priest at St. Susanna's Church for 24 years, and he hasn't shied away from using the parish's Nativity scene in the past to focus attention on social issues. Gun violence. Climate change.

Separating children from migrant families at the border. All of these have been highlighted at the church's Christmas crèche near the Boston city line.

But his use of this year's nativity scene to protest the mass detention of immigrants by masked federal agents has sparked a national controversy that is rippling far beyond this quiet suburb.

"There are so few voices that seem to come out and say 'no' to this administration," Josoma, 70, said Tuesday in an interview at St. Susanna's



The Rev. Stephen Josoma said he aims to be a good priest.

they ordinarily occupy are these words: ICE WAS HERE.

rectory. "I don't get that. I don't understand that."

Outside the church's doors, the Nativity scene does not include the centerpiece figures of Jesus, Mary, and Joseph. In the empty space

"The Holy Family," the sign's text continues, "is safe in the sanctuary of our church." A phone number to report activity by US Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents is listed at the bottom of the sign.

The Archdiocese of Boston has asked that the sign be removed because of its "divisive political messaging," according to a statement issued last week by spokesman Terrence Donilon.

But in Josoma's view, "any divisiveness is a reflection of our polar-

PRIEST, Page A6

## DOWN IN THE CLOUDS



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

It's been a colder than normal December so far and Tuesday morning was one of the most frigid starts, even in Boston, where the steam was rising on Tremont Street with temperatures in the low teens.

### Torment and Trial | Chapter Four

## Prosecutors built a narrative that Latarsha Sanders was 'evil.' Her family felt powerless to stop it.

By Yvonne Abraham | Globe Columnist

**A Family Reels** ■ "She loved them so much," said Edson Brito Sr., a few days after his wife, Latarsha Sanders, stabbed their two youngest children to death. "She would've done anything possible for the kids, anything. Anyone that can say anything other, don't know her. ... That's not the person I know and I married."

It was a cold February night in 2018, and more than a hundred mourners gathered for a vigil outside the family's Brockton home. Community leaders spoke of unfathomable loss and called for better access to mental health treatment. Family members held each other and told the crowd that the woman who had done this was not the person they knew.

A shrine had been growing for Marlon Brito, 8, and La'son Brito, 5, their friends and neighbors coming by the triple-decker on Prospect Street to leave stuffed animals, prayer candles, and balloons.

Somehow, the family made it through the wake, the funeral Mass at St. Edith Stein Church, and the burial at Melrose Cemetery, where two child-sized caskets — Marlon's decorated with a Spider-Man theme, La'son's with PAW Patrol — were lowered into the ground.

SANDERS, Page A10



PHOTOS FROM SHALEA SANDERS; NOTEBOOK SCANS YVONNE ABRAHAM; PHOTO ILLUSTRATION BY RYAN HUDDLE/GLOBE STAFF

*Latarsha Sanders was convicted of first-degree murder for killing her children Marlon, 8, and La'son, 5, in 2018, even though she was experiencing severe symptoms of mental illness at the time. This series explores what led up to the horrific day when Sanders killed her sons, and how the justice system treated Sanders and her family afterward.*

## State may help with long-term care costs

Payroll tax could provide funding

By Kay Lazar  
GLOBE STAFF

Reality came in a gut punch, delivered matter-of-factly by the Needham couple's local bank teller. The total balance in their accounts was barely enough to buy a few weeks of groceries.

Michael Brown had always been meticulous and careful in managing the family's finances. But his wife, Jane, hadn't realized he had slipped into the fog of early-onset Alzheimer's. Amid his confusion and the erosion of his health consulting business, he had quietly burned through the couple's savings and his retirement accounts, trying to keep ahead of the bills.

Jane Brown would soon discover how much she needed that money as she struggled to care for her husband at home. For a decade, until her husband's death three years ago at age 71, Brown patched together assistance from family to help pay for some of Michael's home health aides. Eventually, he qualified for long-term disability payments and for Medicaid to cover many of the health care bills. She also took a reverse mortgage on their house and didn't retire from her full-time job at a non-profit until two years ago, at age 72.

Now, state health leaders are considering creating a public

CARE, Page A6

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### Sprinkle sprinkle

**Wednesday:** A little rain.  
High 44-49. Low 31-36.

**Thursday:** Snow showers.  
High 34-39. Low 20-25.

Sunrise: 7:02    Sunset: 4:11

**Weather and Comics, G6-7.**

**Lexington voters approved replacing their 70-year-old high school campus** with a new building for \$660 million. **B1.**

**Massachusetts employers cut 11,100 jobs in September**, the biggest monthly loss since the start of the pandemic in early 2020. **B5.**

**The EPA has removed references to human-**

**caused climate change** from its website. **A5.**

**The Red Sox are focused on bringing back Alex Bregman but remain interested in Pete Alonso**, sources at the Winter Meetings said. **C1.**

**This year's cookbook crop has many candidates for holiday giving** — too many to narrow down, really, writes Devra First. **G1.**



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